

SDP



Which Copilot Where?

A Practical Surface Router

Route eligible work by decisive context, review ownership, and the capability the team needs next.

"Which Copilot surface should own this work next?"

Start where the decisive context and controls already live.

Route by context, artifact, reviewer, and handoff.

Developer

Choose the surface that keeps implementation context close.



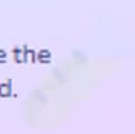
Product + Docs

Explore, shape, and delegate without beginning in an IDE.



Test + Design

Review evidence and move beside the implementation only when needed.



1 shared map

See local, GitHub, remote, and embedded execution.

4 outcome branches

Route without memorizing product names.

A first win

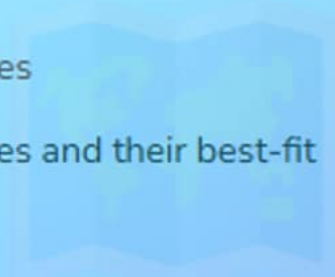
Onboard each role through useful, reviewed work.

PART 1

Map the Surfaces

See what each surface does

Compare seven experiences and their best-fit work.



PART 2

Start by Role

Choose a useful first task

Onboard every discipline through reviewed outcomes.



PART 3

Build Adoption Maturity

Advance through evidence

Turn usage signals into reviewed capability growth.

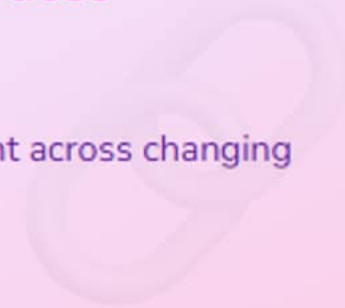


PART 4

Compose the Surfaces

Design visible handoffs

Walk a production incident across changing boundaries.



Click any section to jump directly there

Map the Surfaces

Separate where you steer from where work happens, then route with four questions.



Control

Where do you steer?



Execution

Where do tools run?



Artifact

What comes back?

Two independent axes

↳ **control location** × **execution location**

The Copilot Surface Matrix

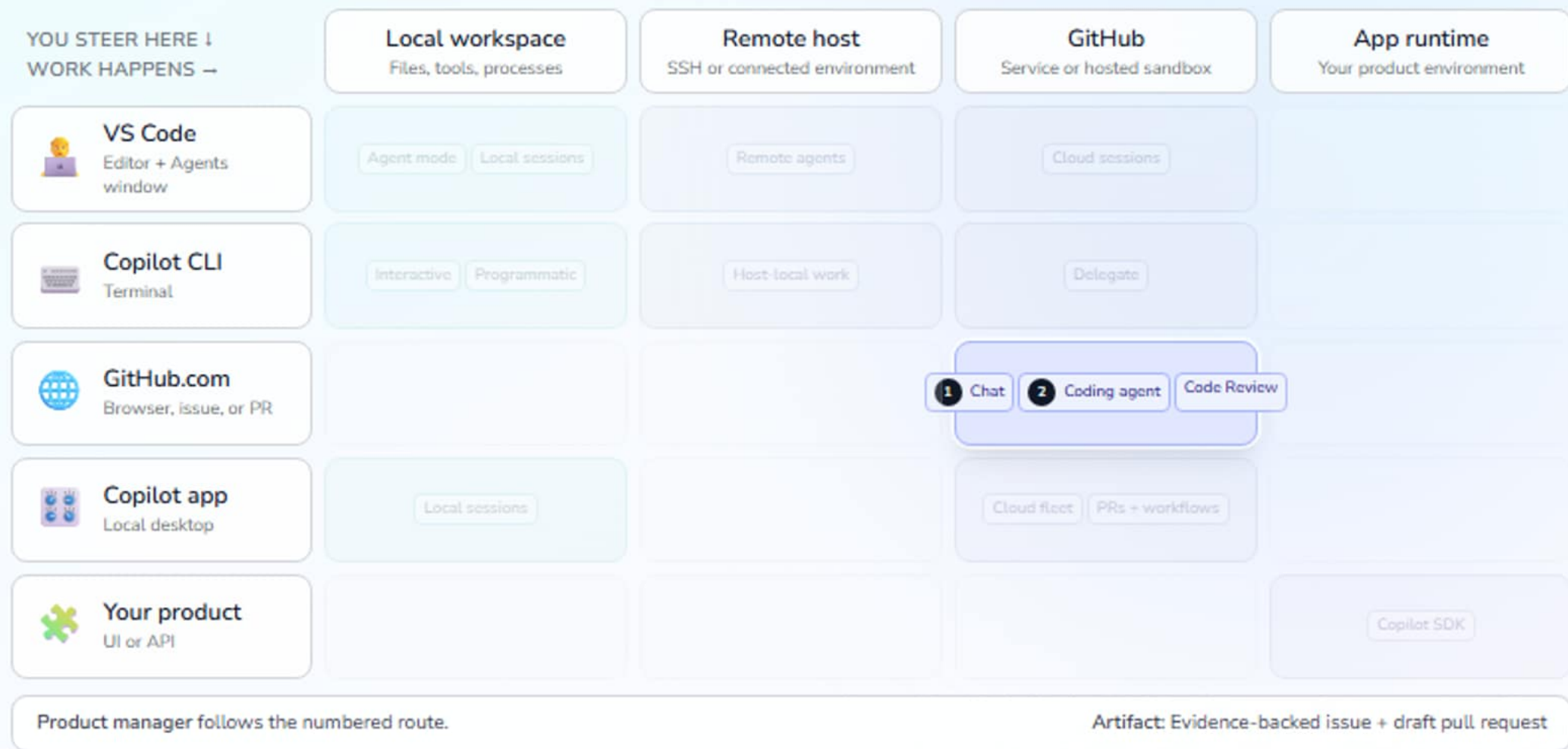
Rows show where you steer · Columns show where execution or analysis happens

YOU STEER HERE ↓ WORK HAPPENS →	Local workspace Files, tools, processes	Remote host SSH or connected environment	GitHub Service or hosted sandbox	App runtime Your product environment
 VS Code Editor + Agents window	Agent mode Local sessions	Remote agents	Cloud sessions	
 Copilot CLI Terminal	Interactive Programmatic	Host-local work	Delegate	
 GitHub.com Browser, issue, or PR			Chat Coding agent Code Review	
 Copilot app Local desktop	Local sessions		Cloud fleet PRs + workflows	
 Your product UI or API				Copilot SDK

Off-diagonal cells are the key: your control surface can steer work somewhere else.

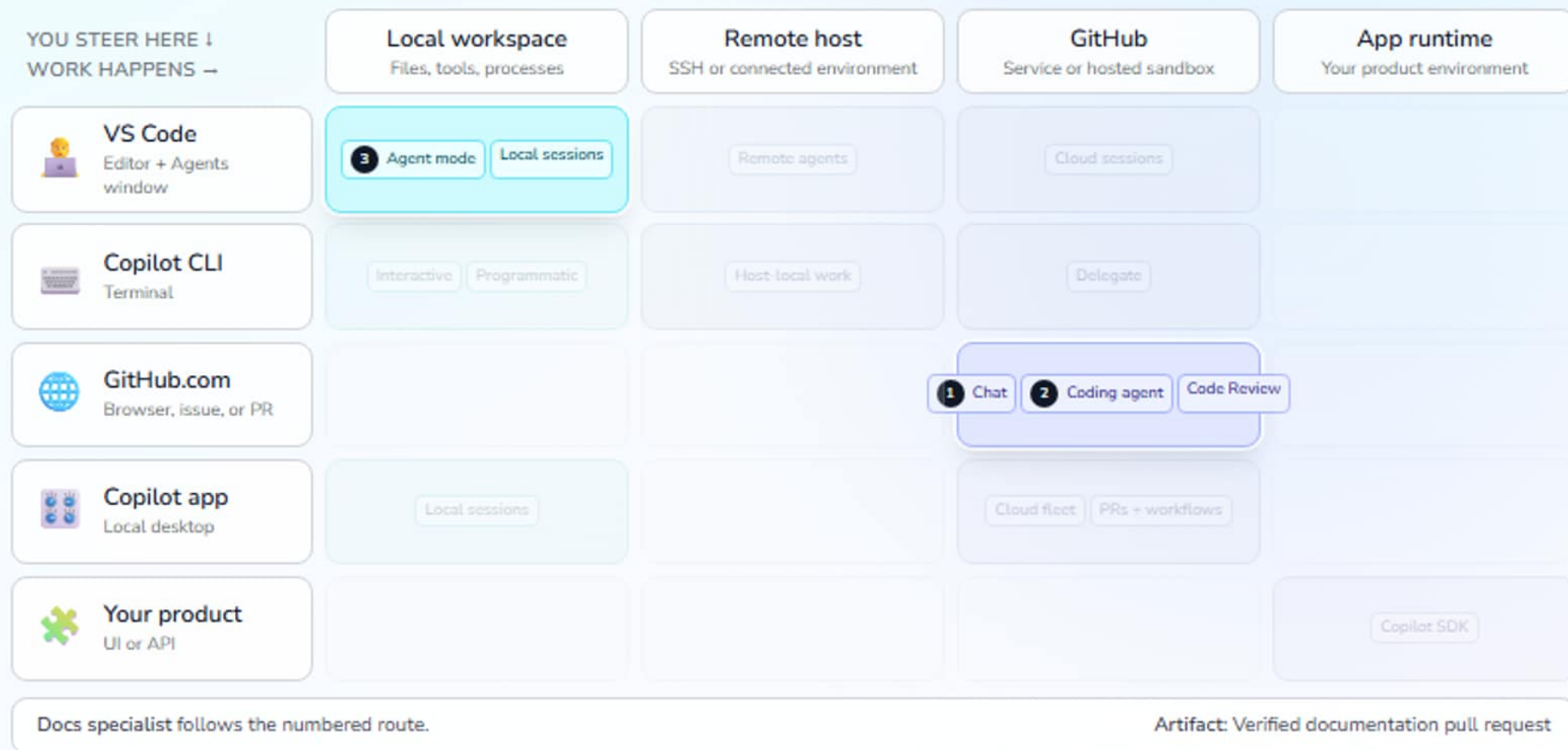
PM: Understand → Shape → Delegate

Stay in GitHub: learn the repository, define acceptance, then hand off a bounded issue



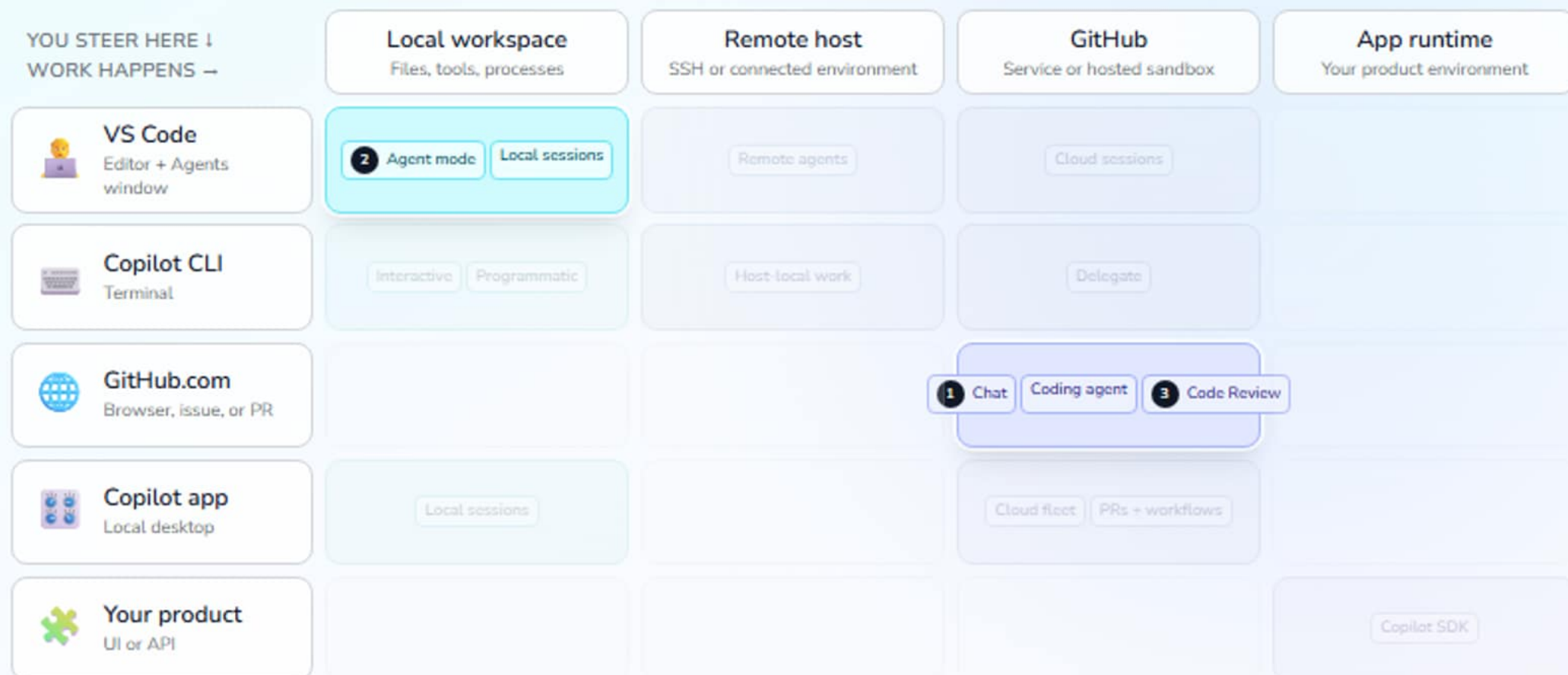
Docs: Discover → Draft → Refine

Use repository context before editing; keep editorial acceptance with the docs owner



Designer: Explore → Iterate → Review

Start with implementation facts, then move beside the UI when visual feedback becomes decisive

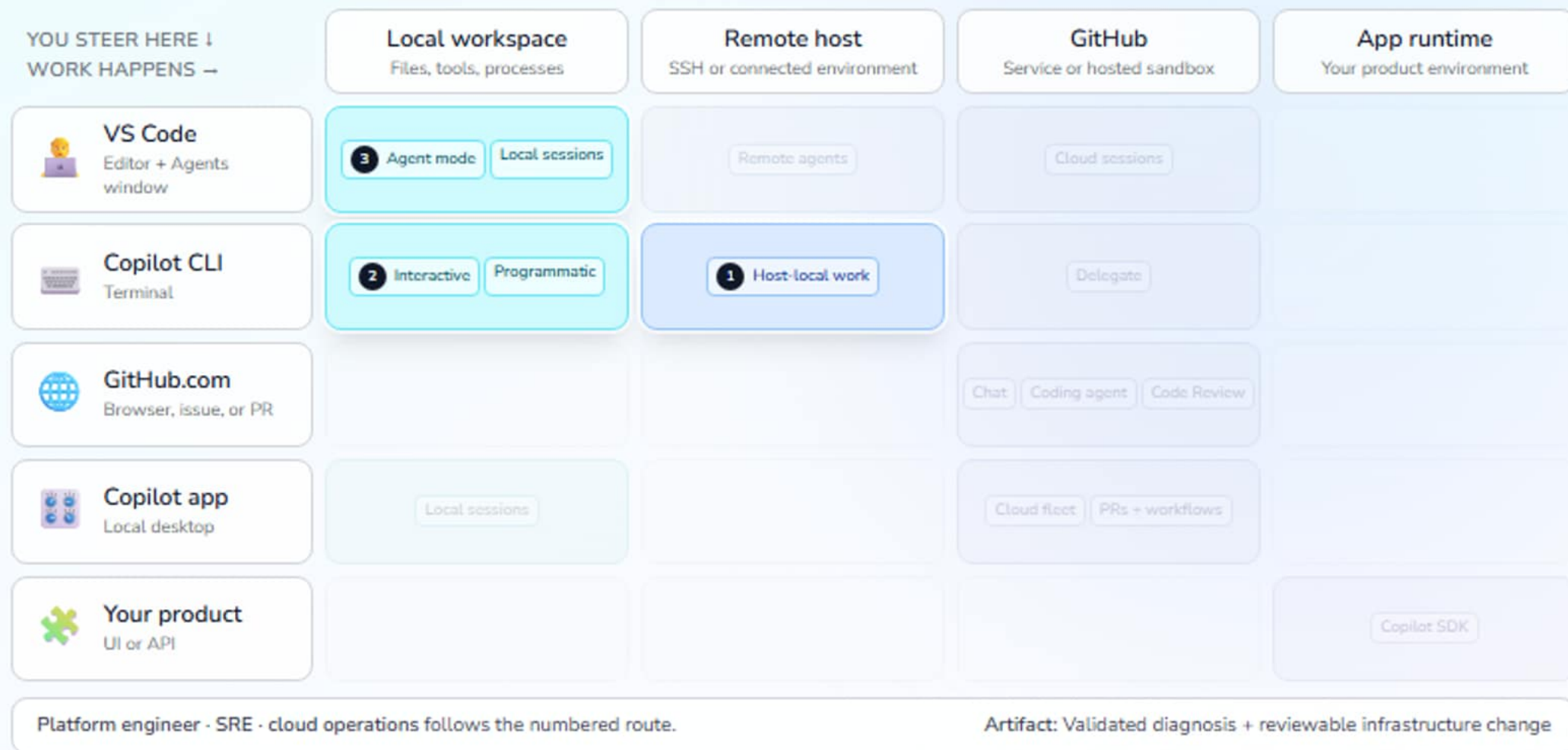


Product designer follows the numbered route.

Artifact: Implemented UI change with visual acceptance evidence

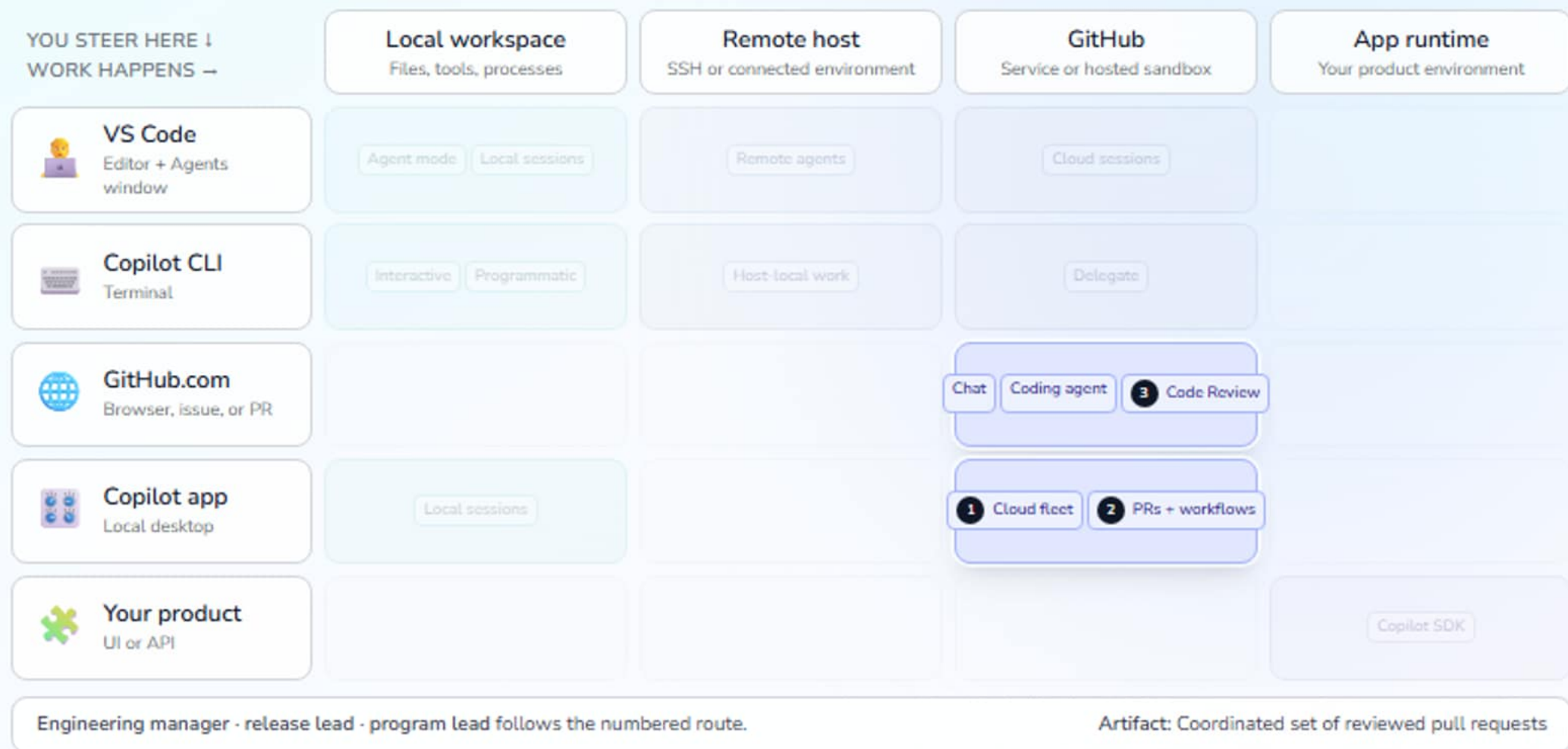
Platform Team: Diagnose → Prove → Encode

Start in the CLI when runtime state is decisive; move only after the remediation becomes repository work



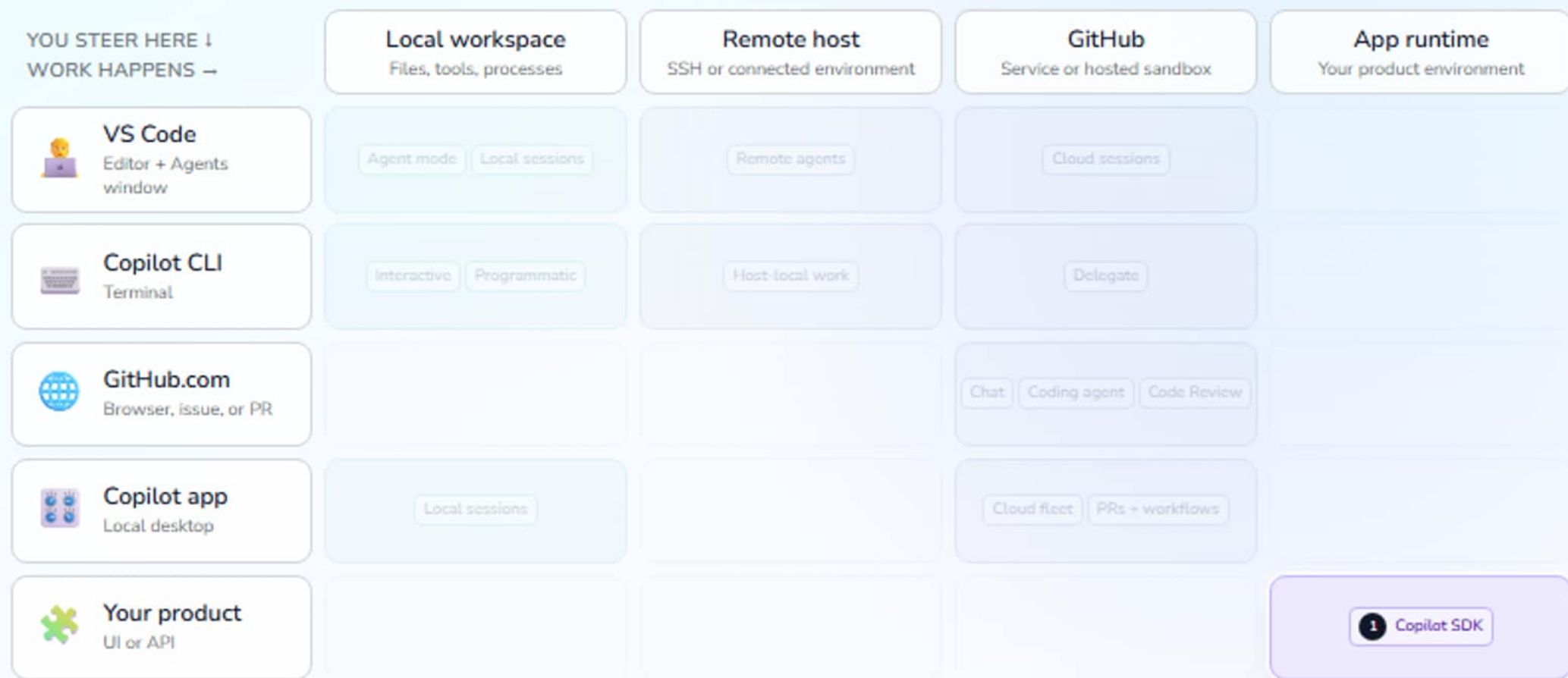
Delivery Lead: Dispatch → Monitor → Accept

Start in the Copilot app when several bounded streams are ready and coordination is the work



Platform Product Team: Embed the Workflow

Start with the SDK when Copilot must live behind your trigger, tools, policy, and product experience



Platform engineer - internal tools team - support automation owner follows the numbered route.

Artifact: Governed agent workflow inside the product

Route by Outcome, Then by Context

Your role suggests a first branch; the artifact and decisive context choose the surface

START WITH THE WORK, NOT THE JOB TITLE

What must exist when this work is done?



Understand or shape

Need an explanation, brief, or better issue?

Often starts with: PM · designer · support

Repository and GitHub context

GitHub Chat

Explore without a local checkout



Review or accept

Need findings or evidence before approval?

Often starts with: tester · docs · reviewer

PR or changed code

Code Review

Find risks; humans accept



Create or change

Where is the context you cannot cheaply recreate?

Often starts with: developer · platform · docs · design

Files, UI, diagnostics

VS Code

Steer interactively

Shell, host, runtime

Copilot CLI

Work beside live evidence

Bounded issue

Coding agent

Return a draft PR



Scale or repeat

Are you coordinating work or embedding capability?

Often starts with: platform · lead · product

Many independent streams

Copilot app

Coordinate the fleet

Inside your product

Copilot SDK

Own the runtime contract

When the artifact or decisive context changes, return to the tree and route the next phase.

PART 2

Start by Role

Give every role one useful first task, one reviewable artifact, and one clear handoff.

1

First task

Choose low-risk real work



Artifact

Produce something reviewable



Handoff

Move when context changes

Role-based onboarding

↳ First win → evidence → next surface

First Wins for PM and Documentation

Product manager · GitHub Chat

First task

Map an unfamiliar feature from repository evidence

Ask

Explain behavior, dependencies, open issues, and user impact

Keep

A cited brief plus acceptance criteria for one bounded issue

Move when

The issue is ready: coding agent returns a draft PR

Docs specialist · Chat → agent

First task

Find docs made stale by one merged product change

Ask

Identify affected pages, source evidence, and examples

Keep

A verified docs PR reviewed by the documentation owner

Move when

Tone or structure needs judgment: refine in VS Code

First Wins for Test and Design

Tester · Code Review

First task

Review one bounded PR for missing tests and edge cases

Ask

Focus on changed behavior, failure paths, and test evidence

Keep

Findings plus a human acceptance or rejection decision

Move when

A finding needs reproduction: use VS Code or CLI

Designer · Chat → VS Code

First task

Trace one interface from design intent to implementation

Ask

Locate components, tokens, states, and accessibility behavior

Keep

An implemented UI change with visual acceptance evidence

Move when

The PR is ready: Code Review checks implementation risk

First Wins for the Copilot App and SDK

Copilot app · fleet owners

Who

Engineering managers, release leads, and program leads

First task

Coordinate three independent, review-ready backlog items

Keep

Visible status, bounded escalation, and a reviewed PR set

Do not start here

When the work still needs discovery or close code steering

Copilot SDK · product owners

Who

Platform engineers, internal tools teams, and automation owners

First task

Embed one proven workflow behind a real product trigger

Keep

Structured output, policy controls, telemetry, and escalation

Do not start here

For a one-off task that an existing surface already handles

PART 3

Build Adoption Maturity

Use telemetry to locate the starting point and reviewed capability evidence to advance.



Baseline

Locate current behavior



Evidence

Review real artifacts



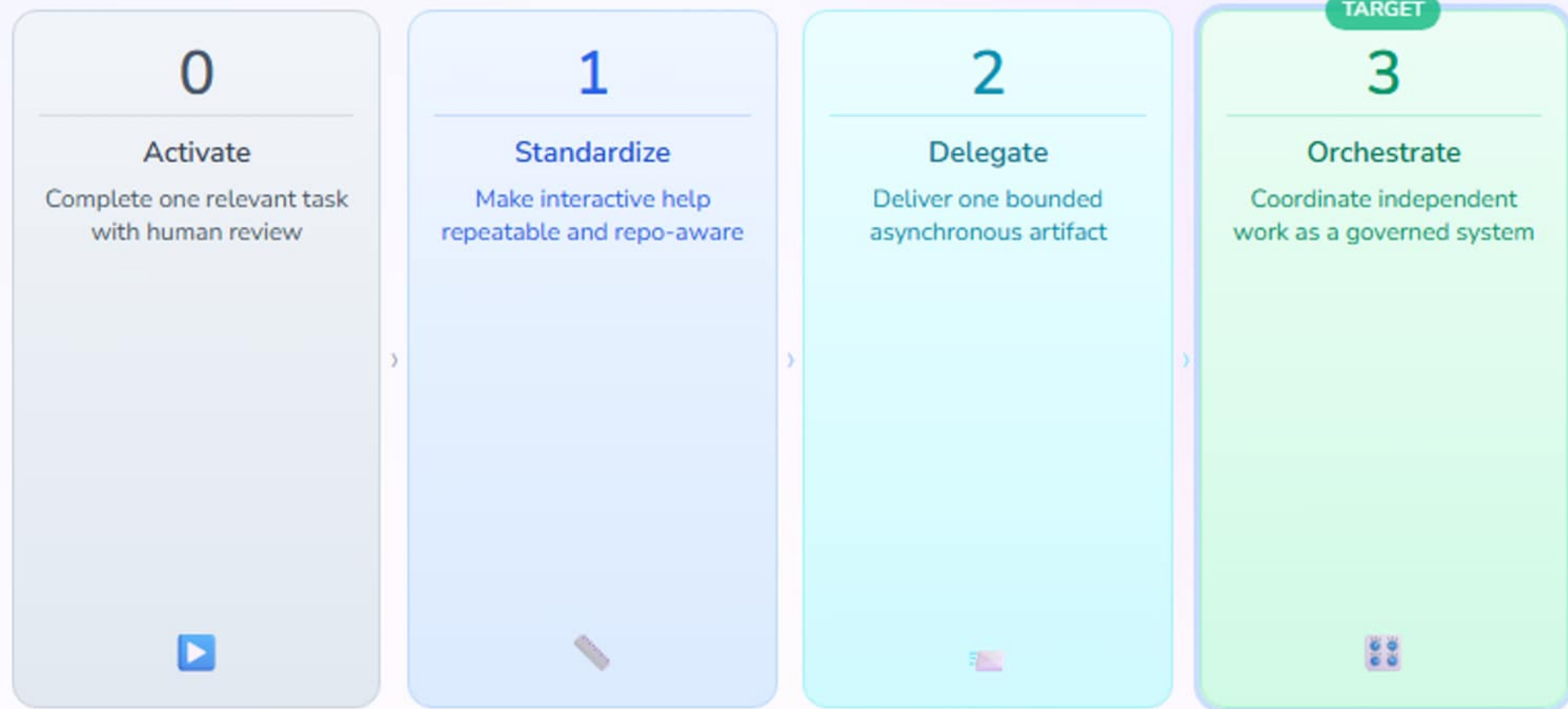
Threshold

Define quality locally

Configurable adoption cadence
↳ 4 phases → reviewed evidence

Four Phases, One Evidence Gate

Telemetry locates the start; reviewed outcomes earn advancement



Maturity belongs to a workflow, not permanently to a person.

The Capability Scorecard



Baseline

Record recent behavior and the delivered outcome for this workflow.



Reviewed artifacts

Count normal-work outputs accepted by the named reviewer.



Quality guardrail

Define the local threshold and escalation limit before advancing.



Next-phase target

Name the next capability the team must demonstrate.

PART 4

Compose the Surfaces

Walk one production diagnosis across CLI evidence, a VS Code fix, and delegated follow-up.



Diagnose

Collect runtime evidence



Fix

Change with repo context



Delegate

Continue with review

Prepared incident walkthrough
↳ Evidence → fix → follow-up

Diagnose Where the Runtime Lives

Keep host-local evidence on the affected machine

```
$ copilot  
> "Inspect the failing process and host-local logs. Do not change code yet."
```

Copilot CLI:

- Read process state and recent logs
- Separate the runtime symptom from the repository defect
- Return evidence and a bounded remediation boundary

- ✓ Runtime evidence stays on the affected host
- ✓ A repository configuration defect becomes the next artifact

Control: immediate human steering at the prompt

Restore Now, Prevent the Repeat

The incident ends after the validated fix; prevention is a separate, optional work item

✗ Single-surface attempt

- 1 Copy logs into the editor
Runtime context is reconstructed
- 2 Change files from the shell
Visual diff and diagnostics are weak
- 3 Keep polishing during recovery
Prevention work delays restoration
- 4 Skip prevention work
The same failure can return

🔄 Recovery slows or prevention disappears

✓ Composed route

- 1 Diagnose in CLI
Incident owner reviews host evidence
- 2 Fix and validate in VS Code
Developer reviews the workspace diff
- 3 Close the incident
The urgent route ends when service is restored
- 4 Optionally delegate prevention
Coding agent adds a regression test and runbook update in a separate draft PR

✓ Service restored + optional prevention PR

Coding agent does not redo the fix; it handles bounded follow-up work asynchronously

Three Reusable Handoff Patterns



Explore → Delegate → Review

A repository question becomes a bounded issue and reviewed PR.

Chat

Coding agent

VS Code



Diagnose → Encode → Productize

An interactive operational proof becomes reusable capability.

CLI

VS Code

SDK



Plan → Fan Out → Integrate

Independent tasks move through coordinated sessions to review.

VS Code or CLI

Copilot app

PR review

Boundary Signals Tell You When to Move

Change surfaces only when the work contract changes

Local state	Keep uncommitted files, services, and credentials local	VS Code/CLI
Unbounded	Explore and plan before asynchronous delegation	interactive
Repeatable	Evaluate an embedded service for proven event-driven work	SDK
Many streams	Coordinate independent sessions from one control plane	Copilot app
Understand	Use repository context without introducing mutation	GitHub Chat

At every transition: name the artifact, evidence, reviewer, and escalation trigger.

From Tool Choice to Explicit Work Routing

Before

- Choose by habit or product familiarity
- Move context manually between tools
- Leave acceptance ownership implicit
- Treat adoption as usage volume

After

- Choose by execution and decisive context
- Move work when a boundary changes
- Name the reviewer at every handoff
- Advance through reviewed capability evidence

7

surface experiences

4

routing questions

3

lifecycle patterns

✓ What You Can Do Today

Today

- Name the decisive context for one task
- Identify its delivery artifact
- Name the accepting reviewer

This Week

- Test the four routing questions
- Document one visible handoff trigger
- Review one capability artifact

This Month

- Baseline your team across four phases
- Set local quality thresholds
- Practice all three lifecycle patterns

🔑 Key Takeaway

Start the work where its strongest context and controls already live.

 Official Documentation[GitHub Copilot documentation](#)

Product-wide concepts and workflows.

[GitHub Copilot in VS Code](#)

Editor integrations, chat, and agent workflows.

[About GitHub Copilot CLI](#)

Terminal-native capabilities and operating model.

[GitHub Copilot Code Review](#)

AI findings for pull requests and changed code.

 Agents and Embedding[GitHub Copilot app](#)

Desktop session management and coordination.

[GitHub Copilot SDK](#)

Agent capabilities for applications and services.



Which Copilot Where?

Route by context. Hand off by boundary. Review by contract.

7 experiences

One visible landscape

4 questions

One practical router

3 patterns

One composable lifecycle

Which task should your team route differently next?